

Chapter 77-1

After Liang Shi got home, she took a shower and put her dirty clothes in the washing machine.

Her stomach was completely empty, so she went to the kitchen to cook, but her mind wandered while she was doing it.

Without realizing it, she had already grown accustomed to having two people around. When she came home in the evenings, there was always another person there—either watching TV on the sofa, or with a light on in the study, or she would need to cook enough for two.

But today she knew Xu Qingzhu wasn't here; she hadn't come back after leaving home.

She should have eaten dinner already.

She only made a single portion.

While eating, she kept subconsciously glancing toward the door. It was clearly just the wind blowing outside, yet it always gave her the illusion that Xu Qingzhu had returned.

In the evening, she kept wanting to talk to someone about what happened at the nursing home today.

It seemed to be a habitual desire to share.

Because after she shared things with Xu Qingzhu, Xu Qingzhu could offer ideas.

When that cool, clear voice resonated through the villa, it was particularly pleasant to hear.

After Liang Shi finished eating, she leaned her body back and slumped in the chair.

Her phone was within arm's reach on the table. She picked it up several times to check, and upon finding no messages, put it back down again.

Actually, she really wanted to know what was happening on Xu Qingzhu's end—whether the conversation was going smoothly, whether there had been any unpleasantness.

But she was also afraid that this might be a critical moment in Xu Qingzhu's discussion, and sending a message would disturb her.

While hesitating, she went to clean up the dining table, then sat back down in front of the sofa, continuing in the same state as before.

It wasn't until the hour hand passed "9" that she finally picked up her phone and sent Xu Qingzhu a message: [Teacher Xu, is the conversation going smoothly?]

Chapter 77-2

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When Xu Qingzhu saw the message, she was sitting on the bed in a daze.

Sheng Linlang had gone back to her room to wash up. Xu Qingzhu sat there flipping through a photo album that Sheng Linlang had hidden away. Inside were many photos of Sheng Qinglin—a spirited young man.

He had the most fashionable hairstyle of that era, rode a cool motorcycle, and was dressed all in black.

There were also photos of him in his school uniform, standing out particularly brightly among the crowd.

Xu Qingzhu had inherited most of her appearance from him, so everyone often said she looked like her mother, when in reality she resembled Sheng Qinglin.

A young talent, who died in the prime of his youth.

One could only sigh regretfully and say that heaven was jealous of his brilliance.¹

Even unrelated strangers would wring their hands and sigh upon seeing this, let alone family members.

After Xu Qingzhu finished looking through those photos, combined with what Sheng Linlang had told her, she suddenly felt that this uncle she had never met in over twenty years had come alive.

No, perhaps she should call him father.

This person seemed to have once vividly existed in her life.

The photo album was still beside her when her phone vibrated slightly and the screen lit up.

Seeing it was a message from Liang Shi, she smiled and casually replied: [Very smoothly.]

Liang Shi: [That's good.]

Xu Qingzhu: [I won't be coming back tonight.]

Liang Shi: [Okay.]

Liang Shi responded very quickly. Xu Qingzhu stared at the screen, not knowing what else to say.

After a while, Liang Shi asked again: [Have you eaten dinner?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Already ate, how about you?]

Liang Shi: [Just ate.]

Xu Qingzhu finally thought of a topic to ask about: [Did you go to the nursing home and see Director Gu?]

Liang Shi: [Yes, but it didn't go very smoothly.]

Xu Qingzhu: [What happened?]

Liang Shi: [As soon as I mentioned Yang Jiani, he had an episode and kept saying "crazy person, crazy woman," so I couldn't find out anything.]

Xu Qingzhu could feel her helplessness even through the screen. Her finger paused on the screen for a moment, and after thinking for a few seconds, she replied: [Then that means Gu Xingyue is connected to Qi Jiao and Yang Jiani. Otherwise, why would Director Gu react like that? If we can't deduce it forward, we'll just deduce it backward. At least it wasn't a wasted trip.]

Liang Shi: [...Teacher Xu is clever.]

Xu Qingzhu: [It's Teacher Liang giving me the chance to show off.]

Liang Shi: [...]

"Who are you chatting with?" Sheng Linlang had changed into her pajamas, her hair still wet, and walked in to ask her, "Is it with Liang Shi? You look so happy chatting."

Xu Qingzhu raised her head, restraining her smile, and asked back, "Do I?"

She was just casually chatting with Liang Shi.

"Yes, you do." Sheng Linlang smiled and said, "Seeing that you two have a good relationship, I can rest easy."

Xu Qingzhu pouted, "Anyway, you all just want to marry me off and have me never come back."

"What kind of thing is that to say." Sheng Linlang gave her a light, sideways glance, "Who was the one who insisted on marrying Liang Shi back then? I tried to stop you."

"I know." Xu Qingzhu curved her lips into a light smile, "It was me."

Back then, Sheng Linlang had wanted her to date Liang Shi for a few years before getting married. After all, she had just graduated and was still young, and Liang Shi had that kind of reputation outside.

But she couldn't resist Liang Shi's relentless pursuit at the time, and with Minghui's decline, she wanted to help Minghui.

Moreover, she had genuinely wanted to marry Liang Shi back then. In her memories, she was still that warm older sister from childhood.

Various reasons stacked up, leading her to enter into marriage with Liang Shi without thinking it through clearly.

The result was disappointment that grew with each passing day.

But now...

Things seemed to have taken an unexpected turn.

Xu Qingzhu didn't tell Sheng Linlang about all the twists and turns. She just needed to let Sheng Linlang know that she had been doing quite well all along.

After their earlier conversation, Xu Qingzhu said she wanted to sleep with Sheng Linlang tonight—it had been too long since they had sat together and chatted.

Sheng Linlang went to bed early at night and was already sleepy by now.

Xu Qingzhu hurriedly washed up, turned off the lights, and lay on the bed snuggled up next to Sheng Linlang.

She didn't bother with her phone anymore.

Actually, it wasn't even close to Xu Qingzhu's usual bedtime, but she had been rushing around busy with work during the day, and after coming back in the evening, her nerves had been tense the whole time. Now, being with Sheng Linlang, she felt sleepy too.

Since they had opened up the topic of Sheng Qinglin, Sheng Linlang lay there telling her stories from their childhood.

Sheng Linlang said that one of Sheng Qinglin's good friends had pursued her back then. This made Sheng Qinglin so angry that he invited the guy to a boxing gym for a fight and told him: "You're not worthy of my sister."

The guy came to Sheng Linlang for comfort with his beaten-up face, and Sheng Linlang stomped on him several more times.

Because Sheng Qinglin's face had also been injured by the other guy.

There was another time when Sheng Qinglin went traveling out of town with a group of friends. Their major had a general education course with a particularly strict teacher who always took attendance. So he asked Sheng Linlang to help answer roll call for him.

It was Sheng Linlang's first time doing something like this, and it was Su Yao who helped her muddle through it.

She answered roll call for Su Yao, and Su Yao answered roll call for Sheng Linlang.²

After class, the two of them went to eat shaved ice³ at the school gate, and along the way, three people asked for their contact information.

Footnotes:

¹ "Heaven was jealous of his brilliance" (天妒英才, tiān dù yīng cái) - A Chinese idiom used to express sorrow when talented individuals die young. It implies that heaven itself was envious of their talent and took them away prematurely.

² This refers to a common practice in Chinese universities where attendance is taken by calling out names from a roster, and students must respond "到" (dào, meaning "here" or "present"). Friends sometimes help answer for absent classmates to avoid them being marked absent.

³ "Shaved ice" (吃冰) - A popular dessert in Chinese-speaking regions, consisting of finely shaved ice topped with various sweet toppings like fruit, condensed milk, red beans, or flavored syrups. It's especially popular in warm weather.

Chapter 77-3

When Su Yao called Sheng Qinglin and told him about this, Sheng Qinglin came back to the school that very afternoon and directly asked Su Yao: "Which ugly bastard is chasing after my sister?"

Su Yao was stunned, then asked angrily: "Shouldn't you be more concerned about me?"

Sheng Qinglin was also stunned: "Have you ever thought about anyone else?"

Su Yao: "....."

Sheng Qinglin wrapped his arm around Su Yao's shoulders, smiling with confidence and boldness: "There's no one better than me in this world."

At that time, Sheng Linlang was standing across from them, holding a camera she had just recently bought, and took a photo of the two of them.

Xu Qingzhu still remembered the photo album she had just flipped through, and asked: "Was it that one under the peach tree?"

"Yes." Sheng Linlang's voice was gentle, filled with endless nostalgia and longing, "Peach blossoms had even fallen on Su Yao's shoulder. I thought Su Yao was really beautiful at that moment."

"That photo was taken with a great sense of atmosphere." Xu Qingzhu praised.

Sheng Linlang smiled and said: "Really? I had just started learning photography back then and couldn't take good photos of anything yet. But those two were good-looking, so no matter how I photographed them, it wouldn't turn out bad."

But Xu Qingzhu asked: "How come I haven't seen you take photos all these years? Staying cooped up at home all the time, it's easy to get sick from being so shut in."

Hearing this, Sheng Linlang's expression changed slightly, but she gently closed her eyes and patted her shoulder while saying softly: "I did take photos of you kids when you were little. You lying on your desk, nestled in your room doing puzzles, swinging on the swing—so many, so many. Later when you all grew up, you wouldn't let me take photos anymore."

Sheng Linlang's movements were light and gentle, as if she were coaxing a child.

Her speech was very slow, softly and gently recounting the stories of those years. As she talked, Xu Qingzhu grew drowsy and soon fell asleep.

Sheng Linlang tucked the blanket around her, then lay on the bed and let out a soft sigh. Her gaze traced over those brows and eyes that looked so much like Sheng Qinglin's, and she said in a low voice: "You have to be well."

Only then would it not let down everyone's protection of you.

Having heard so much about Sheng Qinglin and Su Yao these past few days, Xu Qingzhu even dreamed about the two of them.

They were holding hands freely on campus, traveling to the seaside.

The dream had a soft filter over it, and Xu Qingzhu seemed to have taken on Sheng Linlang's perspective.

Watching them freely and safely pass through their youth.

But after all the beauty, she arrived at that street corner again, where Sheng Qinglin had carefully changed into a well-tailored suit, holding flowers and a ring as he came to the place where he and Su Yao had agreed to meet, only to be tragically hit by a car and sent flying.

The scene suddenly turned black and white, interwoven with the color of blood.

"Beep— Beep—"

The phone rang, and Xu Qingzhu rolled over and felt for the warm phone.

Half of it had been pressed under her body, and she hadn't noticed at all.

She swiped to answer with her eyes half-closed, her head resting on one arm, tears falling onto the bedsheet. When she answered, her voice was hoarse, carrying the softness of having just woken up.

Having had a nightmare, she was subconsciously scared, so her response was somewhat choked with sobs, sounding like she was acting spoiled: "Mm?"

"You fell asleep?" Liang Shi's voice rang out in the room.

From the camera on Liang Shi's end, Xu Qingzhu's long hair fell down, landing on her white silk pajamas. Her entire face was bathed in the dim yellow light of the bedside lamp, casting a hazy glow over her entire being. Half her face was buried in the crook of her arm, her curled and upturned eyelashes fluttering slightly, yet she couldn't seem to wake from the nightmare—sad and sorrowful.

Xu Qingzhu's lips were a vivid red but somewhat dry. Her milky-white skin was so clean and luminous that no pores could be seen. With her eyes half-open, she looked like a languid cat.

After hearing Liang Shi's words, she let out another soft whimper, sniffled, and said: "Mm~"

She didn't want to open her eyes no matter what, but tears slid past the side of her nose, turning into glistening teardrops that gathered at the tip of her nose before gently falling onto the bedsheet.

Liang Shi asked gently: "Did you have a nightmare?"

Her voice was kept very soft, as if a feather was gently brushing against the tip of one's heart, carrying infinite tolerance and tenderness.

Hearing her voice, Xu Qingzhu furrowed her brows tightly, yet her tone became even softer. Even a single syllable was drawn out: "Mm~"

Liang Shi was about to speak when another person appeared in the camera frame.

Sheng Linlang found a tissue, leaned over and gently wiped away Xu Qingzhu's tears, got up to tuck the blanket around Xu Qingzhu, and then got out of bed.

Chapter 77-4

Xu Qingzhu clearly sensed the movement beside her. When Sheng Linlang got up to leave, she finally struggled to open her eyes and called out in a hoarse voice: "Mom."

"Mm." Sheng Linlang said: "It's still early. You two chat for a bit before going back to sleep."

"Where are you going?" The moment Xu Qingzhu spoke, she felt like her throat had been ground by sand—hoarse.

Sheng Linlang chuckled softly, "You're chatting and acting spoiled with your wife. Am I supposed to stay here and be a third wheel?"¹

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"I'm going back to find your dad." Sheng Linlang said: "After sharing a bed for so many years, I'm not used to having someone else beside me."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She laughed lazily, "Then go ahead."

After Sheng Linlang left the room, Xu Qingzhu picked up the water cup by the bed and took a sip. After drinking, she frowned, and Liang Shi understood: "Is it cold water?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Too cold."

"What nightmare did you have?" Liang Shi asked gently: "Why were you crying so much?"

Xu Qingzhu realized belatedly, "I was crying?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Touch your nose. It's still wet."

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the headboard, tilted her head back, and closed her eyes again. "It was a very sad dream."

"Sorry." Liang Shi said: "I disturbed your sleep."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu sighed softly, even her voice carrying lingering sadness. "I went to bed early tonight."

Even through the screen, Liang Shi could feel her helplessness and couldn't help but ask: "Is it about your mom and dad?"

When this form of address came from Liang Shi's mouth, Xu Qingzhu immediately knew who she was referring to.

Not the Xu family parents, but her biological parents.

She tilted her head slightly, her eyelashes casting heavy shadows on her lower eyelids, her lashes trembling faintly. With her eyes half-closed, she said softly: "Yes."

Two light words, yet they carried all her emotions—too complex to put into words.

"Xu Qingzhu." Liang Shi looked at her through the screen and suddenly said gently: "Let me come to you."

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

"It's too late." Xu Qingzhu said: "It takes half an hour to drive."

"There's no traffic now." Liang Shi said: "It's still early. I can be there in twenty minutes."

Xu Qingzhu was speechless.

Liang Shi added: "I have something I need to discuss with you."

It wasn't until after hanging up the video call that Xu Qingzhu saw the messages Liang Shi had sent her.

[Is it okay to move this Saturday?]

[Although you don't like me asking about everything, I still feel this is something for two people to decide, so I want to discuss it with you.]

[Teacher Xu, what are you doing?]

[Are you asleep?]

[It's not your bedtime yet.]

[We'll move to Zhao Xuning's place. It's a bit small, but I'll give you the master bedroom. It has a bay window.]

[When I have money later, I'll buy a really big one in that complex.]

[I'll have money soon.]

[.....]

Liang Shi, who usually didn't talk much, had an unusually large number of messages today. She had probably sensed that something was off with her emotions, so she kept sending messages.

One every few minutes, but at that time Xu Qingzhu had been chatting with Sheng Linlang and went to sleep after their talk, so she hadn't noticed at all.

Looking at them now, Liang Shi's messages had filled the screen.

It gave her an indescribable sense of security.

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When Liang Shi drove to the Xu family's front gate, she suddenly realized... she had been impulsive.

What she actually needed to say was just about moving on Saturday, and that was merely a clumsy excuse.

The real reason was that seeing the sadness Xu Qingzhu conveyed through the screen, and the fragility beneath her sorrowful expression, she really wanted to be there with her.

Spending the night with unsettling bad emotions would make a person feel miserable.

She had experienced it firsthand, so she wanted to accompany Xu Qingzhu through this sad and difficult night.

In a moment of impulse, she had come up with a clumsy excuse and came over.

But when the car stopped, she let out a light breath.

In what capacity had she come?

In what position had she come?

And where would she stay after arriving?

Liang Shi gently closed her eyes, thought for a moment, and then got out of the car anyway.

She thought to herself: I'll go take a look first. If it doesn't work out, I'll just drive back.

As soon as Liang Shi got out of the car, she saw the person standing at the front gate.

Xu Qingzhu was wearing a light-colored cardigan, with a pure white cotton T-shirt underneath and a pair of loose gray pants. She had cotton slippers on her feet, her hair dancing in the wind. That palm-sized little face looked bright and pure under the faint light.

She stood at the entrance with her arms crossed, looking around, and soon spotted Liang Shi. She smiled at her and gave a light wave.

Liang Shi stood there, and suddenly felt at ease.

She walked over and asked in a low voice: "Why did you come out to wait?"

Xu Qingzhu had been standing outside for a while, and her nose was frozen red. Her voice had also been frozen soft, that cool, clear tone nearly blown away by the wind, leaving only softness. Yet she opened her arms toward her: "Teacher Liang, let's have a hug."

Liang Shi was stunned. Xu Qingzhu had already stepped forward, burying her head in the crook of her neck, her breath falling on her neck and the tips of her hair, her arms tightening around her waist.

Their bodies pressed close without warning. Liang Shi stood dazed for a moment before reaching out to gently pat her back, coaxing her softly: "I'm here."

¹ "Third wheel" (電燈泡, diàn dēng pào) - Literally translates to "light bulb." This is Chinese slang for someone who is an unwanted presence when two people want to be alone together, similar to the English expression "third wheel." The imagery suggests that the extra person is like a bright light bulb, illuminating a situation that the couple would prefer to keep private or intimate.

Chapter 77-5

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After the brief embrace, Xu Qingzhu let go of her and only then answered her question: "The household auntie¹ has already gone to rest. No one can open the door, so you wouldn't be able to get in."

"How long did you wait?" Liang Shi followed her inside.

Xu Qingzhu answered perfunctorily: "Not long."

As soon as Liang Shi got close to her, she felt the chill. While Xu Qingzhu wasn't paying attention, she placed her hand on her neck—it was so cold that Liang Shi shivered.

This sudden approach made Xu Qingzhu instinctively step back, her whole body shrinking slightly. She glanced at Liang Shi, "Teacher Liang, why are you launching a sneak attack?"

Her tone had returned to its usual manner, without any of the fragility seen in the video call.

Liang Shi said in a low voice: "Why are you so cold?"

"It's cold outside." Xu Qingzhu said: "Standing for a while makes you cold."

Liang Shi said: "Then you should have waited for me to arrive before coming downstairs. I would have called you."

"Liar." Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly, "If I hadn't been waiting outside for you, you'd probably be on your way driving back by now."

Liang Shi: "....."

A flicker of uncertainty passed through her eyes, but she quickly said: "How could that be?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled without saying anything.

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu brought her back to her room, then leaned against the headboard, her whole body burrowing into the blanket, before asking: "What did you want to tell me?"

Liang Shi stood up and asked her: "Is there hot water?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "In the kitchen downstairs, same setup as at home."

"Then wait a moment." After saying this, Liang Shi took her cup and went out. The cup still had half a glass of cold water in it.

Xu Qingzhu stared at her departing figure in a daze.

Not long after, Liang Shi returned with a tray carrying a glass of water and a glass of milk.

Liang Shi handed the hot milk to Xu Qingzhu and said with a serious expression: "Do you know why you had a nightmare?"

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

"You didn't drink milk." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: ".....Oh."

Liang Shi held the hot water in her hands, her whole body warming up. She sat on the edge of the bed, but didn't really have anything to say.

It was rather awkward.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu lightly kicked her with the top of her foot through the blanket: "What did you want to talk about?"

Liang Shi paused briefly, "Just asking about the moving situation."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu teased her: "Didn't Zhao Xuning already tell you? Don't ask what you shouldn't ask."

"Then this is something I should ask." Liang Shi said: "It's where you'll be living in the future. What if you move in and feel uncomfortable?"

Xu Qingzhu tucked her loose hair behind her ear: "If I'm uncomfortable, I'll just put up with it. What else can I do?"

Liang Shi looked at her, lightly pressing her lips together: "Are you not planning to stay for very long?"

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "Huh?"

"Never mind." Liang Shi realized she had said too much. "Hurry up and drink. Rest after you finish. You still have work tomorrow."

There was a hint of giving up on herself in her tone.

Xu Qingzhu didn't pay it any mind and lowered her head to slowly drink the milk.

Liang Shi sat on the edge of her bed, drinking the warm water half-heartedly.

She wasn't actually thirsty, and drinking too much water before bed wasn't good anyway, so she only drank half before putting down the cup. Xu Qingzhu quickly finished her glass of milk and placed her cup together with Liang Shi's.

One transparent, one milky white—placed together, they somehow matched.

Liang Shi put the cups on the other side of the room, then stood awkwardly in the room for a while.

Finally unable to help herself, she got up to leave: "You should rest."

She stood in front of Xu Qingzhu's bed, looked down to confirm she was alright, and then reminded her: "Set your alarm. Remember to eat breakfast."

Xu Qingzhu tilted her head up, unexpectedly meeting her gaze.

That cool, clear voice rang out in the room, but the ending rose, carrying an indescribable meaning: "Where are you going?"

"Home." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "You came all the way here just to heat up a glass of milk for me?"

Liang Shi: ".....And to discuss things."

As long as a clumsy excuse wasn't exposed, it could keep being used.

This was her last bit of stubbornness.

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly: "You're leaving after we're done talking?"

"Mm." Liang Shi said: "You have work tomorrow. Go to sleep early."

Xu Qingzhu stared at her, the corners of her mouth continuously upturned, as if something worth being happy about had happened.

Liang Shi didn't ask. She was busy being annoyed with herself.

She had noticed that this kind of thing had been happening more and more frequently lately.

Being annoyed with herself, yet not knowing what she was annoyed about.

In any case, her mood was somewhat low.

She planned to think about it after going home tonight, and calmly digest all the bad emotions by herself.

Just as she was about to turn and leave, Xu Qingzhu reached out and grabbed her wrist. Those cool fingers gently brushed over the blood vessels on her wrist—right where she could feel her pulse.

Her heartbeat suddenly quickened, but Xu Qingzhu's fingertips stopped right there.

"Thump— Thump—"

Liang Shi wanted to pull her hand away, but Xu Qingzhu held on extremely tight. She tugged on Liang Shi's arm again and said gently: "Teacher Liang, stay."

Liang Shi turned back in surprise, meeting Xu Qingzhu's eyes once more.

Those eyes were clear and transparent, yet carried an indescribable sadness.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Chat with me for a while."

Footnotes:

¹ "Household auntie" (阿姨, āyí) - In Chinese households, particularly wealthy ones, this refers to a domestic helper or housekeeper. The term "auntie" is used as a respectful form of address for older women who work in service roles, regardless of actual family relation.

Chapter 77-6

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That night, Liang Shi once again lay beside Xu Qingzhu, sharing one blanket.

Because there was no extra blanket in Xu Qingzhu's room, and fortunately her blanket was big enough, leaving sufficient space in the middle.

Xu Qingzhu was indeed tired. After chatting with her for a while about the Sheng family matters, she fell asleep. Liang Shi wasn't much better off either.

It was just that in the middle of the night, while still drowsy, she felt something cold crawl into her arms. She instinctively held onto it, but that cold hand slipped under the hem of her clothes and landed on her lower back.

She was sleeping deeply and didn't notice, only draping her leg over that cold thing.

The temperature dropped in the latter half of the night. Normally, Xu Qingzhu would curl herself up to ward off the cold temperatures.

Especially during this time of year, when the heating hadn't been turned on yet and the temperature had dropped sharply. Xu Qingzhu naturally had a cold constitution, and every morning when she woke up, her hands and feet would be ice cold.

But on this night, she discovered a heat source in the middle of the night, so of course she rolled toward it.

Thanks to this heat source, she slept very comfortably this time, without any nightmares. When she woke up the next day, even her hands were warm.

.....

It took Xu Qingzhu three seconds to figure out her current situation.

Her hand was resting on Liang Shi's lower back, and she had even lifted up the hem of her pajamas, revealing her lower abdomen. Liang Shi wasn't wearing an undergarment.

Actually, she wasn't wearing one either.

Well... wearing an undergarment while sleeping can cause cancer.¹

And she had lifted it up so much that she could faintly see Liang Shi's...

Their legs were tangled together in a strange position. It was hard to say who was on top of whom, but at least this way they wouldn't be cold.

When Xu Qingzhu lifted her head, she saw Liang Shi's jawline. Just as she was about to move her legs to extract herself, Liang Shi's eyelashes trembled slightly and she opened her eyes.

Xu Qingzhu instinctively tried to pull her hand out, but accidentally bumped into Liang Shi's front.

She even bumped it hard enough that it hurt Liang Shi a bit, causing her to let out a muffled groan.

Liang Shi: "....."

Completely awake now.

The two of them stared at each other, then almost simultaneously released their hands and legs, rolling to opposite sides.

Xu Qingzhu rolled to the left side of the bed, while Liang Shi, with just a slight turn, fell off the bed onto the floor, her head even bumping into the bedside cabinet.

.....

A very muffled thud.

Xu Qingzhu immediately leaned over to look, only to see Liang Shi lying there, her face contorted from the pain.

Fortunately, there was a soft carpet on the floor, so her body wasn't too sore.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and couldn't help but laugh.

Liang Shi cast a resentful gaze at her, and Xu Qingzhu immediately pressed her lips together to suppress her smile.

But there was still a brightness in her eyes—she looked quite happy.

Liang Shi gave her a sidelong glance, then sat up.

Xu Qingzhu reached out and placed her hand on her head, gently rubbing the spot where she had hit the bedside cabinet: "Let me rub it for Teacher Liang. There, it doesn't hurt anymore."

As if coaxing a child.

Liang Shi: "....."

Fine, she kind of liked it.

It was probably psychological, but she felt it didn't hurt as much anymore.

Footnotes:

¹ This is a common belief in Chinese culture (and some other Asian cultures) that wearing a bra or tight undergarments while sleeping can restrict blood flow and lymphatic drainage, potentially increasing the risk of breast cancer. While this claim is not scientifically proven, it remains a widespread belief that influences many women's sleeping habits.

Chapter 77-7

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During breakfast, Sheng Linlang watched Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu with a satisfied expression, piling lots of food onto Liang Shi's plate and reminding her to eat more.

Unable to refuse such warm hospitality, Liang Shi... ate a little too much.

So in the morning, it was Xu Qingzhu who drove her car to drop her off at work, before heading to her own company.

The little episode from last night was glossed over, but Liang Shi got a definite answer from Xu Qingzhu—she said she was going to reunite with the Su family.

However, Su Zhe had given her a choice between two options, but Xu Qingzhu said: "I want both."

When she said this, she was very confident, leaving Liang Shi staring in awe.

Liang Shi then expressed her support.

Liang Shi had already gotten the hang of things at the company, but she still prepared her resignation letter and handed it to Zhou Li on Thursday.

Li Ran happened to see this and asked with some regret: "Are you really leaving?"

"Mm." Liang Shi said: "The boot ceremony¹ for Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo is next week. I'm joining the production crew."

"So soon?" Li Ran said: "What a pity. I thought I could spend another month with you. I've gotten used to having you here."

"We can still keep in touch." Liang Shi smiled.

Li Ran patted her shoulder and grabbed a notebook from the desk: "Future big star, come sign your name for me."

Liang Shi casually signed her name on the paper.

Li Ran took one look and was amazed: "Oh wow, you've practiced this, haven't you?"

Liang Shi smiled without saying anything.

She had signed so many autographs before that she didn't need to practice her signature anymore.

But after Zhou Li received her resignation letter, she held the envelope in her hand and thought for a moment before answering: "Your situation is a bit special, so I need to ask the higher-ups. Do you want to ask yourself, or should I ask for you?"

As soon as Liang Shi heard this, she knew she needed to go find Liang Xinhe first.

So she took back her resignation letter and didn't make things difficult for Zhou Li: "Sister Li, I'll go myself."

So before the end of the workday that afternoon, she went up to the General Manager's office.

She knocked on the door when entering. A voice from inside said to come in. Liang Xinhe had her back to Liang Shi and thought it was the secretary coming in, so she didn't pay attention and continued her phone call: "Look into this company called Zuoye Culture."

A moment later, she added: "My little sister is at this company and wants to terminate her contract now."

"Why is their contract so exploitative? The termination fee is ten million."

"I have the money, but I don't want to give it to them."

"Anyway, look into it. Also, the artists under their company—dig up any dirt you can find on them."

"....."

Liang Shi stood there listening and keenly sensed something. She took out her phone and searched for Guo Xinran on Weibo.²

The bio that popped up had already changed to: Zuoye Culture contracted artist, girl searching for family.

Her Weibo ID hadn't changed yet, but her latest post read: Sharing some good news with everyone. Although it's not confirmed yet, I think I've found my biological parents. They contacted me through the local committee, and they're coming here tomorrow. Even though it's just a possibility, I'm still so happy. This all feels like a dream. When I received their phone call, I couldn't believe it. I'll share more good news with everyone later.

This post had been published the night before last, and the comments were full of blessings and congratulations, along with wishes for her to find her parents soon.

After this post, she hadn't posted anything else.

There were still many people following her family search progress.

Liang Shi put away her phone and immediately understood.

Liang Xinhe also turned around, and upon seeing it was her, she froze for a moment, then asked somewhat stiffly: "When did you get here?"

Liang Shi said: "Just arrived."

She maintained the dignity of an adult and simply handed over the resignation letter: "I'm resigning."

¹ "Boot ceremony" (開機儀式, kāi jī yí shì) - A traditional ceremony held before the start of filming a TV drama or movie in China. It typically involves burning incense and making offerings to pray for a smooth and successful production. The term literally means "turning on the machine ceremony," referring to when the cameras officially start rolling.

² Weibo - A Chinese microblogging platform similar to Twitter, widely used for social networking and following celebrities in China.